

Recognize it

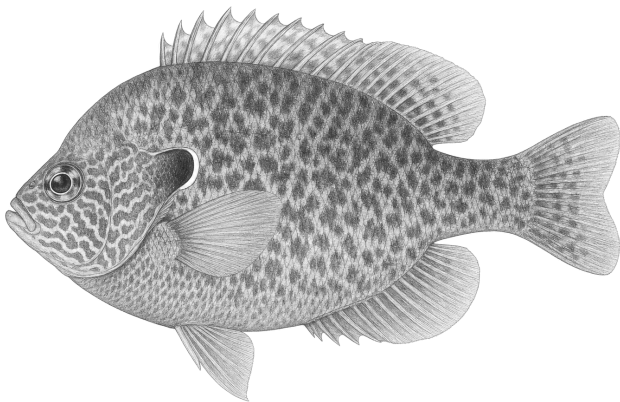
Deep colorful sunfish with turquoise cheek lines and orange/red mark on the ear flap.

Body	Mottled olive sides; orange belly; short rounded pectoral fin.
Mouth/fins	Small mouth; stiff spiny dorsal joined to soft portion.
Confusion	Bluegill lacks the bright ear-flap margin and has a longer pointed pectoral fin.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Vegetated shallows, snails and insect-rich edges, firm spawning pockets.
Food and season
Invertebrates, especially snails and insects; shallow during warm spawning period.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Find it on these waters

Pine	Test protected weed pockets and gravel/sand openings, then the first green outside edge.
North	Test shallow vegetation and firm pockets in protected bays.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Tiny float rig.** Present a worm segment or insect imitation near weed openings without burying it.
- 2. **Micro-jig.** Pitch a compact jig to visible pockets and pause near bottom.
- 3. **Stop rule.** Move when only very small fish respond; do not strip a nesting colony for a meal.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Fold the dorsal spines back, wet hands, and support the body rather than squeezing.

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; panfish daily bag 25 on both lakes as listed 2026-07-26.
Kitchen choice	Use a modest number of thicker mid-size fish; release exceptional adults and active nest guards.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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